

Paul, Richard and Linda Elder. *The Miniature Guide to Critical Thinking: Concepts and Tools*. Dillon Beach, CA: Foundation for Critical Thinking, 1999. 19 pages. \$4.00 spiral/paper. FCT 520M.

Elder, Linda and Richard Paul. *The Miniature Guide to the Art of Asking Essential Questions*. Dillon Beach, CA: Foundation for Critical Thinking, 2002. 47 pages. \$6.00 spiral/paper. FCT 580M.

Paul, Richard and Linda Elder. *The Miniature Guide to Understanding the Foundations of Ethical Reasoning*. Dillon Beach, CA: Foundation for Critical Thinking, 2003. 45 pages. \$6.00 spiral/paper. FCT 585M.

The last two decades have generated a multidisciplinary call for the development and application of critical thinking methodologies at both the K-12 and post-secondary level. Eagerly embraced by educators and lawmakers alike, this critical thinking movement has in some jurisdictions resulted in legislation requiring the integration of critical thinking into academic curricula. As disciplines have scrambled to meet their legislative obligations, a multitude of definitions and approaches to critical thinking have emerged. Richard Paul and Linda Elder, through their work at the Center for Critical Thinking, have developed a series of miniature guides that attempt to define critical thinking, argue for its importance, and provide standards and exercises designed to produce clear and ethical critical thinking. As you would expect to find in a pamphlet-like format, these guides are, at times, abstract, and short on examples and illustrations. Yet, there is something to be said for simplicity. Instructors wishing to integrate critical thinking using non-debate models may find these guides to be a helpful starting point to initiate discussions on critical thinking and ethics. Because the guides do not offer training in the presentation and refutation of argument, their utility with regard to courses focusing on argumentation and debate would stem from their ability to assist in the discovery of issues.

In *The Miniature Guide To Critical Thinking*, the authors begin by defining critical thinking as “that mode of thinking about any subject, content, or problem in which the thinker improves the quality of his or her thinking by skillfully taking charge of the structures inherent in thinking and imposing intellectual standards upon them” (1). To achieve this end, the reader is directed to apply universal intellectual standards – such as

precision, relevance, and fairness to a variety of elements of thought – such as questioning relevant information, inferences, and points of view. Utilizing this methodology enables the learner to work towards achieving the essential intellectual traits: intellectual humility, intellectual courage, intellectual empathy, intellectual autonomy, intellectual integrity, intellectual perseverance, confidence in reason, and fair-mindedness.

Of the three guides reviewed, this is the shortest and most general. In the preface to each guide, the authors make it clear that they are offered as addendums to other courseware, and encourage instructors to apply the principles to real life examples. While it is unfair to expect the depth of analysis available in a textbook, there are many bulleted concepts in *Critical Thinking* where further explanation would be helpful. Essentially, the information in the guide is presented in the form of checklists and questions. The reader gets a sense that a more thorough treatment of these concepts, complete with examples and applications, would have produced a more interesting work. Additionally, it would have been useful to know the origins of these concepts. The authors assert, for example, the universality of the intellectual standards described in the guide. Some might argue that, far from universal, these standards are derived from a Western, linear, reasoning perspective.

On the other hand, the generic nature of the principles discussed in this guide may be attractive to some readers. *Critical Thinking* overviews the theories that form the foundation for the other guides reviewed. Many of the bulleted principles include questions that are designed to critically evaluate problems. For example, fairness is one of the universal intellectual standards asserted by the authors. To test the fairness of their reasoning, readers are encouraged to examine the extent to which they have a vested interest in an issue and whether they are sympathetically representing other points of view.

In the *Miniature Guide to Understanding the Foundations of Ethical Reasoning*, Paul and Elder apply their critical thinking methodology to the subject of ethical reasoning. By way of comparison, this guide is longer than *Critical Thinking*, allowing for a somewhat clearer, more interesting product. The authors begin by explaining the importance of critically evaluating the impact of our actions on others, and the need to avoid egocentric ethical judgments. They then argue that there are three sources of pseudo-ethics: religion, social conventions, and law. The authors would supplant these sources of ethics with ethical absolutes (prohibitions against acts such as slavery, genocide, torture, racism, etc.) supported by the United Nations' Declaration of Human Rights. While law and social convention may be easily dismissed by most readers as illegitimate sources of ethics, the

authors' indictments of religion as a foundation for ethics are likely to be viewed by many readers as an unnecessary diversion from what is generally an uncontroversial treatment of ethics. The authors argue, for example, that because members of religious groups have acted unethically, ethics grounded in non-secular reasoning are faulty. They observe, "that ethical judgments must trump religious belief is shown by the undeniable fact that many persons have been tortured and/or murdered by people motivated by religious zeal or conviction" (8). The reasoning here seems strained. Clearly, abuse of principle does not undermine the soundness of the principle. Additionally, non-secular ethicists probably would contend that secular individuals and groups, such as Hitler, Milosevic, Pol Pot, al Queda, etc., violate human rights with greater frequency.

Having argued for a secular humanist basis for ethical standards, the authors describe an eight-step process that can be used to evaluate the logic of simple ethical questions (questions that virtually answer themselves) and complex ethical questions (questions that require reasoning within multiple viewpoints). The process uses many of the elements of thought described in *Critical Thinking*. When working through an ethical question, the reader is encouraged to define an ethical goal, articulate the key ethical questions involved, assess the information needed to answer the question, apply key ethical concepts/standards, identify their assumptions, consider alternative points of view, review their conclusion, consider the implications of the conclusion. The process is described in a concise manner than easily can be applied to classroom discussions of ethical issues. Instructors who base their argumentation courses in academic debate may welcome this process as a non-adversarial methodology for approaching ethical questions – investigating ethical questions through traditional academic debate formats can produce discussions that skip along the peripheries of the important issues. Additionally, this process could be used to aid in the discovery and invention of issues and arguments that might then be challenged within the context of a debate.

In a section that would interest debaters intrigued by language critiques, the authors discuss the general semantics notion that thinkers can become biased by their language use. Ethical thinkers must realize that the human tendency is to view the world as us vs. them. Paul and Elder call for ethical thinkers to reject broad judgments such as "evil" and "good" and replace them with more specific language that describes ethical and unethical behavior. Ethical concepts are "embedded in natural language" (18). To illustrate this point, the authors describe a sampling of desirable and undesirable ethical concepts and the language

choices that reflects those concepts. For example, the ethical good of being forthright can be described as being honest, loyal, faithful, and trustworthy. Causing emotional discomfort can be described as being rude, ill-mannered, unkind, and hateful. The authors walk a kind tight rope here between ethical relativism and absolutism. Their concurrent acceptance of some ethical labels (honest, rude, etc.), while rejecting broader notions such as good and evil is interesting. It is clearly important to avoid overgeneralization and ethical hyperbole, but it would be interesting to know if the authors believe that any behavior rises to the level of evil. Paul and Elder contend that each of us is a mixture of both. But is a genocidal dictator any less “evil” for having exhibited some good qualities?

The authors divide ethical questions into simple questions (questions that virtually answer themselves) and complex (questions that can be argued in more than one way). In an interesting examination of complex questions, the authors apply their ethical model to the issue of euthanasia. This is one of the best sections in the guide as it provides the reader with an example of the internal dialogue that might be part of reasoning through an ethical question. As the dialogue concludes, it becomes obvious that questions surrounding the ethics of euthanasia are not easily answered. The authors observe that the ethics of the issue may differ depending upon the circumstance.

In *The Miniature Guide to The Art of Asking Essential Questions*, Elder and Paul encourage the reader to practice critical thinking by becoming good questioners. Much of the material presented in the *Critical Thinking* and *Ethical Reasoning* is subsumed within the context of this tribute to the Socratic method. The authors revisit content such as the elements of thought and the nature of ethical reasoning, emphasizing the types of questions implied by those areas. The guide is divided into four parts: analytic questions, evaluative questions, questioning within academic disciplines, and questioning for self-knowledge and self-development.

While there is substantial redundancy with the other guides, a few of the features unique to this guide warrant comment. In the section dedicated to analytic questions, the authors divide conceptual questions into simple and complex. Simple questions can be settled by defining terms – what the debate community might refer to as propositions of fact. The authors argue that complex questions must be settled through “argumentation” (11). While a process for analyzing concepts is provided, there is no instruction given regarding how these questions should be argued. Even if viewed as a personal reasoning process, there are important omissions in their methodology. For example, as part of their analytical process,

the authors call for the inclusion of “multiple viewpoints” (a theme repeated in the other pamphlets as well). Unfortunately, the authors provide no standards for evaluating competing viewpoints

On the other hand, this section includes an interesting treatment of asking complex interdisciplinary questions. The authors encourage the reader to consider the various domains of thinking/fields associated with a question. Examples of the various types of questions associated with each field are provided. Within the context of an argumentation course, this section could be used in conjunction with a discussion of field dependency.

Another feature unique to this guide is an application of the elements of reasoning to asking fundamental questions about academic disciplines. The authors argue, and it is a point well taken, that students too frequently ask superficial questions, such as, “will this be on the test?” *Essential Questions* encourages students to question instead the purpose and core assumptions of courses. The authors provide interesting examples of questions designed to probe the logic behind specific disciplines such as sociology and the arts. Though not specifically applicable to the study argumentation, the general goal of encouraging students to look beyond the surface of the courses they are taking enriches any discipline.

Despite the ambiguities produced by the limited size of these guides, there are elements of each that are recommendable. It would be unnecessary, however to adopt all three of the guides. Because the *Essential Questions* includes so much of the material from the *Critical Thinking* and *Ethical Reasoning*, it would seem to represent the most complete treatment of the authors’ perspective on critical thinking available in the abbreviated guide format.

The general theme that emerges from each of the guides is that the reader should question the underlying assumptions behind reasoning. This theme is certainly not new to argumentation, but alternative approaches to similar material can be illuminating. Instructors wishing to integrate a general unit on critical thinking may find the approach taken in the miniature guide series a refreshing supplement to a traditional argumentation text. What is clearly missing, however, is instruction in the construction, presentation, and refutation of argument. Consequently, instructors who ground their courses in academic debate may prefer the specific tests of evidence and stock issues analysis that have emerged from our discipline over the less focused offerings of these guides.

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